PRACTICE BRIEF

Tamarind Hill College: the fees list

A free, self-paced business analysis case from the Practeva BA Starter Toolkit. Tamarind Hill College, its people and its data are fictional.

How to use this brief

Work through the seven tasks in order. Each one matches a technique in the toolkit and a template you can download from practevahq.com/toolkit. Allow two to three hours per task. Finish the tasks before you read "Check your work" at the end.

1. The situation

Tamarind Hill College is a private secondary school in Port Harcourt with 240 students from JSS1 to SS3, two arms per class. Fees are paid each term: ₦250,000 for junior secondary and ₦290,000 for senior secondary. A few students have half scholarships.

Parents pay into the school's bank account, by transfer or by deposit at a branch, or by card at the bursary. The bursary matches payments to students using the bank statement. At the end of the third week of term, the bursary emails each form teacher a list of students with outstanding fees, and those students are sent home until they pay.

This term the list had 94 names on it. On Monday 28 September 2026, the parents' WhatsApp groups filled with screenshots of transfer receipts, and the PTA chair called the principal before 8am.

2. The memo

From	Mrs Ibiere Alalibo, Principal
To	Project team
Date	29 September 2026
Subject	Fees app

Yesterday was embarrassing. Parents who had paid were told their children owed fees, and some children went home in tears. This cannot happen again next term.

I want parents to pay fees through an app, so payments go straight into our records and the bursary stops chasing tellers. Mr Sekibo tells me he can build something over the holiday. I have asked the board for ₦3 million, and they want a recommendation from you by the end of October.

Please look into it and tell me what we need.

3. What people told you

Summaries of your first conversations. Treat them as you would real interviews: some of it is fact, some is opinion, and some needs checking.

Person	Role	What they said
Mrs Ibiere Alalibo	Principal	"The board asked me why we cannot just do what other schools do. I need something I can explain to them by the end of October."
Mr Chukwudi Anyanwu	Bursar	"We download the bank statement every Friday and tick off payments against the student list. If the narration has the child's name, it is easy. A lot of the time it says TRF FROM and a parent's name, and I do not know every parent. Those go on a suspense sheet. In the first three weeks of term my two assistants and I stay late most days." Asked about the list: "I send what the records show. If it is not matched, it is not paid, as far as the records go."
Mrs Folake Oyelaran	Chair, Parent Teacher Association	"Parents do not trust the bursary's list any more. Some families pay for two children in one transfer. Nobody ever told us what to write in the narration. And we do not get receipts unless we go and collect them."
Mr Tari Sekibo	Computer studies teacher; runs the school website	"I can build a web app with a payment gateway over the holiday. I would need hosting and the gateway's fees." Asked who would support it during term: "Me, in between my classes, I suppose."
Ms Hadiza Umar	Account officer at the school's bank	"We can give each student a unique payment reference or a dedicated account number, and send a statement file every day. The school has never asked for it." Asked about cost: "There is a setup process and a charge per transaction. I would need to send you our current rates."
Mr Ikechukwu Ude	Form teacher, JSS2A	"I get the list on a Monday morning and have to read the names out in class. Three of the five I sent home last term came back the same day with receipts."

4. How fees are handled today

The bursar walked you through the process.

1. A parent pays at the bank (transfer or branch deposit) or by card at the bursary.
2. For card payments, the bursary records the payment against the student straight away and prints a receipt.
3. For bank payments, the parent is asked to send the receipt or bring the deposit slip to the bursary. Some do; many do not.
4. Every Friday, an assistant bursar downloads the week's bank statement as a spreadsheet.
5. The bursar matches each line to a student, using the narration, any receipts parents sent, and memory.
6. Lines that cannot be matched go onto a suspense sheet. Nobody follows them up unless a parent complains.
7. At the end of week three, the bursar exports the students whose matched payments do not cover their fee and emails the list to form teachers.

8. Form teachers send the listed students home.
9. Parents who have paid come to the bursary with proof. The bursar matches the payment by hand and the student returns.

5. The data

Three files exported on 28 September 2026, covering payments from the two weeks before term to the end of week three. Download them from practevahq.com/toolkit.

File	One row per	Columns
tamarind-hill-students.csv	student	student_id, first_name, surname, class, parent_name, fee_due
tamarind-hill-payments.csv	line on the bank and card statement	payment_id, value_date, amount, channel, narration, matched_student_id (blank if the bursary could not match it)
tamarind-hill-unpaid-list.csv	student on the week-three list	student_id, class, outstanding

> **No database needed.** Open the files in Excel or Google Sheets, or import them into a free browser tool such as SQLite Online (sqliteonline.com) and query them with SQL. If you use SQL, name the tables students, payments and unpaid_list.

6. Your tasks

Task	What to produce	Template or tool
1. Frame the problem	A problem statement that separates the problem from the solution the principal asked for.	Problem statement
2. Map the stakeholders	A register with power and interest ratings. Name anyone who could block or quietly undermine a change.	Stakeholder register
3. Plan an interview	A guide for a follow-up with the bursar: five open questions and the probes you would use.	Interview guide
4. Model the as-is	A BPMN diagram of the current process with lanes for parent, bank, bursary and form teacher. Mark where things go wrong.	bpmn.io or draw.io
5. Test the assumption	Answers to the five data questions below, with the query or formula you used.	SQL or a spreadsheet
6. Write requirements	At least five user stories with acceptance criteria (Given, When, Then) for your chosen option, plus three non-functional requirements.	User story pack
7. Recommend	One page to the principal and board: the problem, the evidence, the options, your recommendation and what it will take.	Your own words

Data questions for task 5

1. How many rows does the statement have, and how many are duplicates? What other data quality problems can you find in the three files?
2. Once the data is clean, how many payments are unmatched, and what are they worth?
3. How many students on the unpaid list have an unmatched payment that names their parent?
4. How many students on the list paid part of their fee? How many have no payment you can find at all?
5. Which payment channel produces the most unmatched payments?

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Check your work

Read this after you have finished the tasks. There is more than one good answer for most of them; these are the things a strong answer covers.

Data answers

Question	Answer
1. Rows and quality	220 rows, of which 4 are exact duplicates (the same payment ID twice). There is also a ₦290,000 transfer that was reversed the next day (a positive line and a matching negative line), and 6 students whose class is typed inconsistently, such as "jss2a" or "SS 1B".
2. Unmatched payments	41 unmatched payments worth ₦12,450,000, after removing the duplicates and the reversed pair.
3. Listed, but the parent paid	35 of the 94 students on the list have an unmatched payment that names their parent.
4. Part paid and not paid	27 paid half their fee. 19 have no payment you can find. The other 13 sit behind 11 unmatched payments that name nobody ("SCHOOL FEES", "TRF"). The amounts fit their fees, but the statement alone cannot prove which payment is whose. That is a finding too.
5. Channel	Bank transfers (29) and branch deposits (12). Card payments at the bursary are never unmatched, because they are recorded against a student at the counter.

One way to answer question 3 in SQL

```
SELECT COUNT(DISTINCT u.student_id) FROM unpaid_list u JOIN students s ON s.student_id = u.student_id JOIN (SELECT DISTINCT * FROM payments) p ON p.matched_student_id = '' AND CAST(p.amount AS INTEGER) > 0 AND p.narration LIKE '%' || s.parent_name || '%';
```

What the evidence says

About half the students on the list (48 of 94) had paid in full. The main problem is not that parents fail to pay or that paying is hard. Payments arrive without a reference the bursary can rely on, unmatched payments wait on a suspense sheet nobody works, and the list goes to form teachers without being checked against it.

What a strong answer covers

- **Problem statement:** describes students who have paid being sent home and payments that cannot be matched. It does not say "we need an app".
- **Stakeholders:** includes the form teachers and the bank's account officer, not only the principal and bursar. Notices that the PTA chair has high interest and real influence, and that support for an in-house app depends on one teacher's spare time.
- **Interview guide:** asks the bursar about the last suspense sheet, how long it is, and what happens to it before the list goes out.

- **As-is model:** shows the suspense sheet as a dead end and the list going out without anyone checking it.
- **Data:** removes duplicates and the reversal before counting, and separates "paid but unmatched", "part paid" and "not paid".
- **Options:** compares at least three. A unique reference or account number per student with daily statement matching; a parent payment app; and a process fix first (work the suspense sheet and call parents before any child is sent home). Strong answers compare cost, time, risk and who supports each one, and often start with the first and third before deciding on the second.
- **Requirements:** acceptance criteria someone could test, and non-functional requirements on parents' and students' personal data, availability at the start of term, and receipts.
- **Recommendation:** leads with the answer and the evidence (48 of 94), says what the data cannot prove, and asks the board for a decision.

Want feedback on your work?

The BA Bridge Cohort runs a full case like this over twelve weeks, live online, with feedback on every deliverable. Join the waitlist at practevahq.com.